

Artifact: The "3-Tier" Modular Camp Kitchen Checklist



Most people dread the "kitchen shuffle" when camping. You know the feeling: you're hungry after a long hike, but the stove is buried under the sleeping bags, the spatula is in a random grocery bag, and you can't find the dish soap to save your life.

The goal of a modular camp kitchen isn't just to look organized for a photo. It's about efficiency. When everything has a specific home in a specific bin, you stop searching and start cooking. You spend less time managing "stuff" and more time enjoying the woods.

At Outdoor Pack List, we recommend a **3-Tier Modular System**. By breaking your kitchen down into three distinct bins, you create a workflow that mimics a professional kitchen: Prep, Cook, and Clean.

The Philosophy of the Modular Bin

Before we dive into the lists, let's talk about the bins. We recommend using heavy-duty, stackable plastic bins (like the ones from Rubbermaid or specialized camping brands).

- **Tier 1 (Bin 1): Prep & Storage.** This is your "pantry and tool" box.
- **Tier 2 (Bin 2): Cooking & Fuel.** This is your "heat" box.
- **Tier 3 (Bin 3): Sanitation & Waste.** This is your "clean-up" box.

By separating these, you can pull out exactly what you need without exploding the entire contents of your trunk onto the campsite table.

Tier 1: Prep & Storage (Bin 1)

This bin is the heart of your workspace. It contains the tools you need to get food ready and the "dry" pantry items that don't need a cooler. When you start making a meal, this is the first bin you open.

The Checklist:

- **Cutting Boards:** One large or two small. Thin, flexible plastic sheets work great to save space.
- **Knife Set:** A chef's knife and a paring knife. Always keep these in sheaths to protect the blades (and your fingers).
- **Prep Utensils:** Spatula, large spoon, tongs, and a whisk.
- **The "Spice Kit":** A small, airtight container holding salt, pepper, garlic powder, and red pepper flakes.
- **Cooking Oil:** Transfer oil into a small, leak-proof squeeze bottle.
- **Dry Goods:** Coffee, tea, bread, and snacks.
- **Storage Bags & Foil:** A roll of aluminum foil and a handful of reusable silicone bags for leftovers.
- **The "Small Stuff" Bag:** A mesh bag inside the bin for a bottle opener, can opener, and wine corkscrew.



Pro-Tip: Label the lid of this bin "PREP." When you're at the picnic table, this bin stays on the left side. It's your staging area.

Tier 2: Cooking & Fuel (Bin 2)

Tier 2 is all about the heat. This bin is often heavier and contains items that might get a little soot or grease on them. By keeping the stove and pots separate from your dry food (Tier 1), you prevent cross-contamination and keep your pantry items smelling like food, not fuel.

The Checklist:

- **The Stove:** Whether it's a two-burner propane stove or a compact backpacking stove.
- **Fuel Canisters:** Always bring one more than you think you need.
- **Lighting Sources:** Two lighters (one as a backup) and a box of waterproof matches.
- **Pot & Pan Set:** A nesting set is best. We recommend one medium pot and one 10-inch skillet.
- **Pot Holders/Oven Mitt:** Vital for moving hot metal over an open flame.
- **Coffee Maker:** An Aeropress, French Press, or a simple pour-over cone.
- **Cast Iron Skillet (Optional):** If you're car camping and don't mind the weight, this is the gold standard for camp cooking.



Safety Note: Never store your fuel canisters at the bottom of the bin under heavy pots. Keep them on top or in a side compartment where they won't be crushed or punctured.

Tier 3: Sanitation & Waste (Bin 3)

This is the most neglected bin, but it's the one that determines how much you enjoy the end of the night. Nobody wants to hunt for a sponge in the dark. Tier 3 is your "Scullery."

The Checklist:

- **Collapsible Wash Basins:** You need two: one for soapy water, one for rinsing.
- **Biodegradable Soap:** Campsuds or Dr. Bronner's (remember, even biodegradable soap should be used 200 feet from water sources).
- **Scrubbers & Sponges:** A heavy-duty green scrub pad and a soft sponge.
- **Dish Towels:** Two quick-dry microfiber towels.
- **Paper Towel Roll:** Keep this in a plastic bag to ensure it stays dry.
- **Trash Bags:** Small kitchen bags and at least two heavy-duty contractor bags.
- **Hand Sanitizer:** For quick clean-ups before and after handling meat.
- **The "Drying Rack":** A small mesh bag you can hang from a tree or a foldable rack to let dishes air dry.



The "5-Minute Setup" Protocol

The point of a modular system is speed. When you arrive at your site, don't just dump the bins. Follow this protocol to create a functional kitchen in under five minutes.

1. **Clear the Table:** Wipe down the campsite picnic table. If you use a tablecloth, pin it down now.
2. **The Triangle Layout:**

3.
 - **Left:** Tier 1 (Prep & Pantry).
 - **Center:** The Stove (from Tier 2).
 - **Right:** Tier 3 (Cleaning).
3. **Water Access:** Place your 5-gallon water jug at the end of the table near the Tier 3 bin.
4. **Trash Station:** Hang your trash bag away from the food prep area, but within walking distance.
5. **Light it Up:** If it's getting dark, strap a headlamp to your water jug (facing inward) to turn the jug into a glowing lantern for the whole table.



Bear-Proofing Your Tier System

If you are camping in bear country, your modular bins are a major "attractant." The bin system makes bear-proofing much easier because you aren't chasing down loose bags of chips or stray spoons.

1. The "Scent-Lock" Rule:

Everything that has a scent goes into the bins. This includes the stove (which has food residue) and the dish soap. If it's not in the cooler, it's in a bin.

2. Storage at Night:

Unless the campsite provides a metal bear locker, all three bins (and the cooler) must go back into your vehicle at night or whenever you leave the site. Because they are stackable, this should take about 60 seconds.

3. The 200-Foot Rule:

In high-activity bear areas or backcountry sites, your "Kitchen Triangle" (where you cook and store bins) should be at least 200 feet downwind from your "Sleeping Zone."

4. Grey Water Disposal:

Never dump your dishwater (Tier 3) right next to your tent. Strain out any food particles, put them in the trash, and carry the water away from the site to dispose of it.

Why Modular Works

The "3-Tier" system is grounded in the idea that camping shouldn't be a struggle. When you know that the lighter is always in the Tier 2 bin and the salt is always in Tier 1, the mental load of camping disappears.

This system is also scalable. Going on a quick solo overnight? Just grab a smaller version of Bin 2. Taking the whole family for a week? Use the full 3-bin setup.

By keeping your gear orderly and practical, you spend less time being a "camp manager" and more time being a camper.

Save this for your next trip. Having a physical or digital copy of this checklist inside your Tier 1 bin will ensure you never leave the spatula on the kitchen counter at home again.

Send this to your trip partner. If everyone knows the 3-bin system, everyone can help cook and clean without asking, "Where do we keep the soap?"

Happy cooking, and we'll see you on the trail.